

S00-01 - The Job

Player read-aloud

At the edge of the warded road, a woman waits beside a loaded carriage. She looks like your contact for this job, but she has not introduced herself yet.

Scene summary

The party meets their contact by description, receives the sealed package, asks questions, and agrees to roll out.

Visible choices

- Ask questions about the crate
- Accept the job without question
- Try to inspect the seal

Player questions

- What do you ask before you accept the job?
- Who checks the package without opening it?
- Who is first into the carriage?

Raw source

- Id: S00-01
- Act: Prologue
- Title: The Job
- Beats: Scene setup Corporate satire beat Lore reveal
- Image: assets/scenes/S00-01-the-job.png
- Short: The party meets their contact by description, receives the sealed package, asks questions, and agrees to roll out.
- Long: A real conversation at the edge of the city. The whole crew, including Marlowe or a chosen replacement PC for Keystone custody, receives the job together. Sabine Quillon can appear here as the optional backup NPC job-giver if the table should not put that role on the Marlowe player.
- Read: The crew gathers at the carriage as the sealed crate waits inside, stamped with enough authorization marks to make opening it feel expensive.
- Gm: Do not play Emeris Crown Holdings as the villain yet. They are the employer and the system. Let suspicion emerge slowly.
- Entities: Marlowe Fairwind Sabine Quillon Escort Carriage Sealed Keystone Crate Route Assurance Contract Emeris Crown Holdings Goldspire Territories Emeris Capital Gate Ward Infrastructure Keystone Asset Sablewood? Logistics Preserve Emeris Clerk Garrick Reed Difficulty Ladder Varian Soto The Grail Short Rest
- Choices: Ask questions about the crate Accept the job without question Try to inspect the seal
- Prompt: Fantasy corporate delivery briefing at dawn: a courier crew gathers beside a

- sealed glowing crate loaded into a carriage; five adventurers prepare gear; subtle corporate seals and permits; no monsters, no strixwolf, no undead.
- Source Entities: Marlowe Fairwind Emeris Crown Holdings Keystone Asset Goldspire Territories
- Beat Codes: scene-setup corporate-satire-beat lore-reveal
- Slug: S00-01-the-job
- Act Title: Act 0 - The Contract
- Arc Role: Contract orientation, played briefing, and threshold transition
- Caption: Played briefing scene: description first, names through dialogue.
- Image Alt: The Job scene art for Act 0 - The Contract.
- Image Prompt Used: Fantasy corporate delivery briefing at dawn: a courier crew gathers beside a sealed glowing crate loaded into a carriage; five adventurers prepare gear; subtle corporate seals and permits; no monsters, no strixwolf, no undead. 4:3 cinematic fantasy concept art, no visible text, no captions, no logos, no UI, no watermark.
- Long Storyboard: A professional but slightly ominous delivery briefing. The crate is heavy, sealed, and important, but the full truth is withheld. The party starts inside the system rather than against it. Run this scene as contract / ordinary frame: The party begins inside the system: hired, trusted, and carrying more risk than they know. Keep the camera close to practical choices, visible consequences, and the difference between ordinary people and the infrastructure pressing on them.
- Read Aloud: At the edge of the warded road, a woman waits beside a loaded carriage. She looks like your contact for this job, but she has not introduced herself yet.
- Gm Notes: Do not play Emeris Crown Holdings as the villain yet. They are the employer and the system. Let suspicion emerge slowly. Keep player-facing information actionable. Reveal systemic truth through objects, reactions, and consequences before naming it. Manufactured-threat lens: seed the contradiction, do not explain it. The surface goal stays simple and heroic. [ADD/GUARANTEED] Grail-branded bounty board: "STRIXWOLF: APEX FOREST HAZARD. Sightings up 300%. Bounty payable in Marks." [ADD/GUARANTEED] Couriers or a clerk trade fearful route gossip: the Preserve "takes one a week now." [ADD/EARNED] A player asking what they know receives the corporate line: strixwolves are vicious pack predators. (Knowledge Easy 10)
- Sensory Details: cold brass permit seals coffee gone bitter in a tin cup crate hinges humming under the morning noise
- Body Language: Marlowe or the chosen replacement PC for Keystone custody receives the job with the rest of the crew If Sabine is used, she keeps her voice even but checks the seal twice Garrick watches the exits by habit Varian tracks the road before anyone asks
- Sample Dialogue: Sabine Quillon If I am your contact today: we are not paying you to open it. We are paying you to make sure nobody else does. Emeris clerk Routine route assurance. The form says routine, and forms are paid to be optimistic.
- Checks: Knowledge or Presence Read the contract pressure without derailing the job. Easy to standard The PCs learn the employer is withholding risk, not necessarily lying. 10/15 Cleanly resolve: Read the contract pressure without derailing the job. Add a concrete boon, extra clue, or improved position. Success, plus the player names one helpful detail or asks one follow-up question. Success, but the GM exposes a cost, ticks a countdown, or reveals a new pressure tied to The Job. The full goal slips, but the party still learns a useful truth or avoids the worst consequence.

The GM makes a hard move that follows from the fiction and leaves the next choice visible. Spend Fear to reveal omitted risk, split attention, or put a human cost in front of the contract. On mixed or sliding results, reveal information in layers: visible fact, actionable clue, then systemic truth. Marlowe's extra Arcana check Give Marlowe's player the per-character job-scene insight; use Knowledge when converting to Daggerheart traits. Standard Marlowe clocks the wardcraft/custody pressure without becoming the job-giver. 15 Cleanly resolve: Give Marlowe's player the per-character job-scene insight; use Knowledge when...

- Choices Consequences: Ask hard questions They get names and practical facts, plus one doubt-flicker. Curiosity is rewarded. Accept and move The run starts clean and professional. Pacing stays fast. Try to open the crate The seal flares and logs the attempt. Later corporate attention becomes easier to justify.
- Clues: Protective seal The seal looks contractual and protective, not decorative. The crate is linked to ward infrastructure, but do not reveal the true name here. Careful inspection can tell the package is important without saying what it is. Guaranteed seed Grail-branded bounty board: "STRIXWOLF: APEX FOREST HAZARD. Sightings up 300%. Bounty payable in Marks." Grail-branded bounty board: "STRIXWOLF: APEX FOREST HAZARD. Sightings up 300%. Bounty payable in Marks." Guaranteed seed Couriers or a clerk trade fearful route gossip: the Preserve "takes one a week now." Couriers or a clerk trade fearful route gossip: the Preserve "takes one a week now." Earned seed Available if players investigate, show mercy, or ask the right question. A player asking what they know receives the corporate line: strixwolves are vicious pack predators. Knowledge Easy 10
- Loot: Authorized route copy Emergency toll voucher A private worry from the contact, if roleplayed for Keystone Asset?: Inside the sealed crate, packed in wax-paper and reassurance, sits a heavy grey stone the size of a loaf, warm to the touch, faintly humming, with a light deep inside it that is slowly going out.
- Payoff Flags: Custodian Trust Track
- Filters: choice corporate-satire-beat custodian-trust-track gm-only lore-reveal prologue scene-setup the-contract npc progressive-disclosure run-beats manufactured-threat guaranteed-earned clue
- Index: 0
- Player Questions: What do you ask before you accept the job? Who checks the package without opening it? Who is first into the carriage?
- Relationship Prompts: Which PC has done a messy delivery job before? Which PC trusts paperwork least?
- Ownership Prompt: One of you takes point in the conversation. Who steps forward first?
- Reveal Hooks: Loreborne or Knowledge-focused PCs can read the institutional layer. Wildborne/community-focused PCs can read local custom and ecological stress. Martial/security-focused PCs can read threat posture and custody logic. Magic-focused PCs can feel ward tone, soul-signal, or spell instability. Loreborne: spots older legal, heraldic, or ward-craft language under the branding. Underborne: notices service doors, hidden routes, and who built the thing nobody credits. Highborne: reads etiquette, class panic, and reputational risk. Ridgeborne: notices stonework, weight, pressure, and structural weakness. Wildborne: reads the land, animals, and local ecological stress. Elf/Ribbet/Human/Giant/Katari: invite one sensory or social detail from the player's heritage.

Sorcerer/Rogue/Warrior/Guardian/Ranger: give each class one table-facing way to shine without changing the plot.

- Fear Spends: Make the contact catch a PC reading her and go guarded. Make the route window feel tighter: a ward marker dims, a clerk hurries them, or weather presses in. Reveal omitted risk or fine print. Make the human cost visible before escalating danger.
- Public Objective: Meet the contact, take custody of the sealed package, ask what you need to ask, and decide to roll out.
- Gm Script: At the edge of the warded road, a woman waits beside a loaded carriage. She has a book, a folded route-map, and the posture of someone trying not to look nervous. She looks across the group and says, 'You're the crew? Good. We're losing daylight.' What do you do?
- Player Takeaway: I can ask practical questions and learn names through play.
- Story Takeaway: The job becomes concrete: contact, carriage, package, destination, pay, and unease.
- Mechanic Takeaway: Optional social/reading rolls can reveal nervousness or corporate framing, but the scene works without dice.
- Gm Checklist: If using Sabine, show the contact image before saying her name. Show the package image only as a sealed crate. Ask 'Any questions before you roll out?' before moving to the threshold.
- Gm Private: Correction reminder: Marlowe stays a PC and the package custodian in the group unless Kyle chooses a replacement PC for package custody. Sabine is optional backup job-giver only for S00-01. Use her when you do not want the Marlowe player to carry the table-facing job-giver role. Everyone receives the job together, including Marlowe or the chosen replacement PC for package custody. Marlowe's player gets her per-character job-scene benefit: bonus insight and an extra Arcana check at The Job. Sabine may not know the full contents either if she is used; do not over-explain the package. Sabine only needs to be in play for this Prologue job briefing and questions. After the handoff, the crew owns the route. The manufactured-danger truth should feel like a faint mismatch, not a reveal.
- Gm Examples: If using Sabine and a PC asks her name: 'Sabine. Sabine Quillon. You're the crew Emeris sent? Good. We're losing daylight.' If a PC asks what's inside: 'Above your pay grade and mine. Sealed means sealed.' If the table stalls: 'She's waiting. Anyone have a question before the carriage rolls?'
- Player Beats: S00-01-contact Meet the contact Your Contact assets/entities/sabine-quillon.png A finely dressed woman with a book and route map waits beside a carriage. A finely dressed woman with a book, a creased route-map, and a fighter's wariness waits beside a loaded carriage. image-title-caption At the warded road, a sleep-frayed woman waits beside a loaded carriage: good boots, worn coat, a book, creased route-map, and the posture of someone expecting trouble. She looks you over. What do you do? Use this beat for Sabine only if you want the optional backup NPC job-giver. If Sabine is in play, do not say her name until the players ask or she introduces herself. Push her image to the player display here. Marlowe remains a PC custodian in the crew and receives the job with everyone else. The contact is a real, frayed person, not just a corporate mouthpiece. Model the core loop: ask a question, get an answer. The woman has a name once I engage with her. Engagement reveals the contact The contact has a name when players ask or she introduces herself. If Marlowe is a PC, do not make Marlowe the briefer. Marlowe receives the

job with everyone else and can still carry custodian pressure. "A...

- Takeaway Help: The briefing is playable. Players can question the contact, inspect the package, and choose how they leave. Keep the scene active. The players should leave knowing they made the job concrete, even if they did not solve the mystery. "This is not a cutscene. Ask the contact what you need to know, inspect what you can see, and decide how your character enters the job." If players ask what options matter: "Ask about pay, route, danger, destination, employer, package handling, who drives, where you sit, and whether anyone checks the crate before departure." Keep the scene active. The players should leave knowing they made the job concrete, even if they did not solve the mystery. roleplay table-spotlight The job becomes physical. Contact, carriage, package, destination, pay, and unease all become visible. A direct roleplay read can give the emotional clue. For sharper detail, use Instinct or Presence 13, or Knowledge 14 for the route story. "Now the contract has a person, a carriage, a sealed crate, a route, and a deadline." If players ask what feels off: "The contact is too competent to be casual and too nervous to be merely bored. The route story sounds rehearsed." A direct roleplay...
- Story Scope: Perceived antagonist: the forest. True antagonist: the corporate lie about the forest. The players never confront it directly. They are meant to feel it by the end. Every act offers at least one guaranteed and one earned hint that the danger is manufactured and the forest is not the enemy. Grail-branded bounty board: "STRIXWOLF: APEX FOREST HAZARD. Sightings up 300%. Bounty payable in Marks." ADD GUARANTEED Couriers or a clerk trade fearful route gossip: the Preserve "takes one a week now." ADD GUARANTEED A player asking what they know receives the corporate line: strixwolves are vicious pack predators. ADD EARNED Knowledge Easy 10 Grail-branded bounty board: "STRIXWOLF: APEX FOREST HAZARD. Sightings up 300%. Bounty payable in Marks." ADD GUARANTEED Couriers or a clerk trade fearful route gossip: the Preserve "takes one a week now." ADD GUARANTEED A player asking what they know receives the corporate line: strixwolves are vicious pack predators. ADD EARNED Knowledge Easy 10 Knowledge Easy 10: recall the corporate strixwolf line if asked. ACT0 Onboarding + Prologue 30 0:00 to 0:30 0:30 pregame, safety, connections, Contract overview, Job briefing, forest threshold Keep the...
- Mechanics: The party is in Prologue pressure: The party meets their contact by description, receives the sealed package, asks questions, and agrees to roll out. Use Daggerheart Duality Dice as baseline. Use the listed Difficulty and outcome options when a roll matters. Keep trivial actions no-roll; roll only when uncertainty, cost, or danger is interesting. s00-01-read-the-contract-pressure S00-01 Read the contract pressure Read the contract pressure Knowledge Presence Knowledge Presence 12 Knowledge reads clauses; Presence reads the briefer or optional Sabine without making any PC the job-giver. The job starts feeling routine when it is not. Critical Success: best possible version of the action; gain Hope and clear 1 Stress. Add an extra benefit that follows from the fiction. Success with Hope: the PC gets what they wanted and gains Hope. Keep the position clean or generous. Success with Fear: the PC gets what they wanted, but the GM gains Fear and introduces a cost, complication, or pressure. Failure with Hope: the PC does not get the full result, but gains Hope and receives a useful thread, clue, or safer next option. Failure with Fear: the PC fails and the GM gains Fear. Make a hard...
- Roll Cards: s00-01-read-the-contract-pressure S00-01 Read the contract pressure Read the contract pressure Knowledge Presence Knowledge Presence 12 Knowledge reads

clauses; Presence reads the briefer or optional Sabine without making any PC the job-giver. The job starts feeling routine when it is not. Critical Success: best possible version of the action; gain Hope and clear 1 Stress. Add an extra benefit that follows from the fiction. Success with Hope: the PC gets what they wanted and gains Hope. Keep the position clean or generous. Success with Fear: the PC gets what they wanted, but the GM gains Fear and introduces a cost, complication, or pressure. Failure with Hope: the PC does not get the full result, but gains Hope and receives a useful thread, clue, or safer next option. Failure with Fear: the PC fails and the GM gains Fear. Make a hard move that follows from the fiction. The job starts feeling routine when it is not. Use a hard complication, lost time, worse position, GM Fear, or mark Stress. Apply an official condition only if the fiction and rules justify it. The attempt falls short, but a partial thread appears. Offer one clue, weak position, or safer follow-up. The PC gets...

- Conditions Hazards: No official condition unless a feature, hazard, or fictional position calls for Hidden, Restrained, or Vulnerable.
- Search Loot Clues: No fixed loot. Offer clue, texture, or hospitality only when the fiction supports it.
- No Roll Guidance: Do not call for a roll when the players have time, a clear method, and no meaningful pressure.
- Tv Mechanics Caption: Public cue: The Job asks what the party does, what it costs, and who is protected.
- Trait Variety Note: Primary traits in this scene: Knowledge, Presence. If rolls drift toward Instinct/Presence, ask whether Agility, Strength, Finesse, or Knowledge better describes the action.
- Factionids: emeris-crown-holdings
- World Connection Prompts: S00-01-emeris-crown-holdings-world-connection emeris-crown-holdings Emeris Crown Holdings You have worked a job like this before. What is the part of the contract you learned to read twice?
- Location Ids: goldspire-territories emeris-capital-gate emeris-capital
- Item Ids: keystone-asset
- Clueids: route-assurance-contracttm the-welcome-broadcasttm nature-is-deadly-placardtm bramble-are-criminals-noticetm
- Clue Ids: route-assurance-contracttm the-welcome-broadcasttm nature-is-deadly-placardtm bramble-are-criminals-noticetm
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